the intellect—fits well. As if this valiant battle of preservation is only about delaying the inevitable: the cultivated normalcy that surrounds talk about a family elder living with a familiar set of life-threatening debilities. Some are forthright with their dire prognoses. Independent scholar-author Rajesh Kumar Singh, for whom decoding Ajanta has represented a life-mission over three decades, is wistful: "I'm convinced these murals will not be with us 50 years from now." Scientists evade an answer. Architect-conservator Abha Narain Lambah, who helmed the team that authored Ajanta's site management plan in 2010, smilingly parries the question with a mock-offensive: "You should be doing a story on Delhi's Tughlak monuments. Ajanta is actually one of our best-managed sites!" Then relents to offer a remark that says a lot by leaving a lot unsaid: "The issues at Ajanta are endemic to the site." Dhar, who has spent years on Unesco restoration projects with old Buddhist thangkas and murals in Tibet and Ladakh, says "the risk is not intrinsic to the paintings" and ties his gloomy analysis to "the management environment"—particularly uninformed, inept conservation.

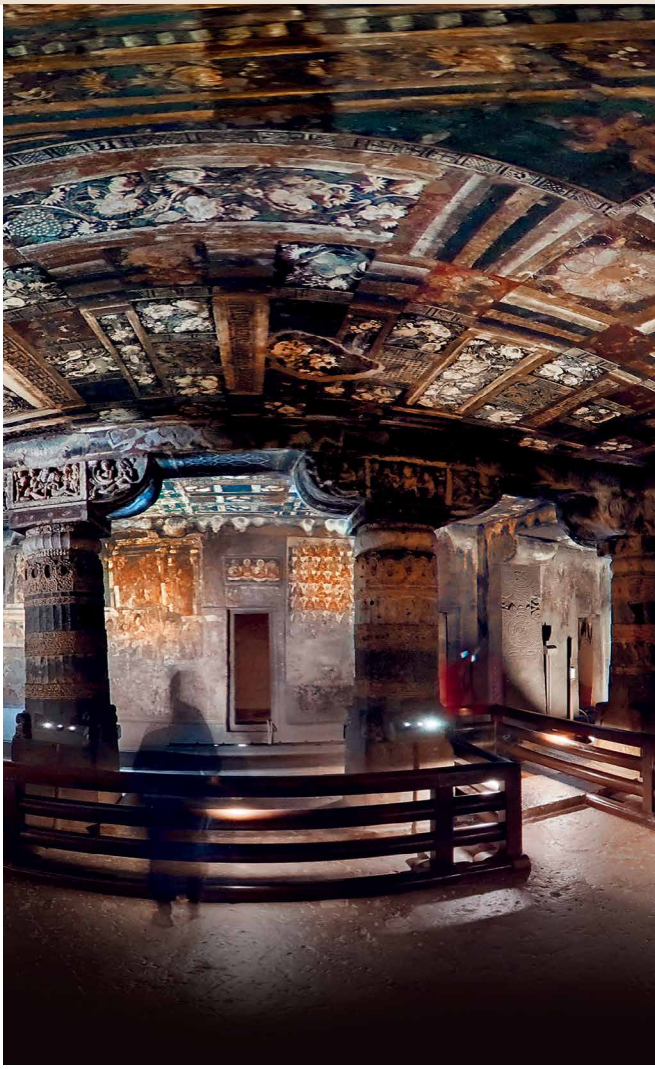
Neither is wrong. But what are these issues? The master architects of Kailashnath at Ellora went top down and dug out that stunning monument in one piece from all that tonnage of cold, sleeping rock. Strung along the backstory, the evidence here has to be pieced together bottom up—to grasp the nature and state of the murals, as it confounds modern conservators, one key theatre is microscopic. The other track is the history of human exaltation...and violence, deliberate or unwitting.

AJANTA: A BROKEN JATAKA

The first piece of art was wrought by the same hand that now poses the greatest danger: nature. Some 66 million years ago, giant volcanic eruptions created the Deccan Traps out of lava that cooled to become basalt—the same rock that forms the moon's dark patches, the *lunar maria*. The Waghora river next cut that, over millennia, into that U-shaped gorge—eerily prefiguring an apsidal Buddhist shrine. Around the late second century BC, the Satavahana period, the first human sculptors began excavating—finding the rock hard but submitting easily to hammer and chisel.

In two of the six caves excavated then, Caves 9 and 10, via the fascinating play of mineral pigments, there came alive a Buddhist tapestry—minus the Buddha, as was the norm in those pre-Mahayana days. "Oil lamps used in worship deposited layers of soot on them. But they painted on a base of lime plaster. That's undamaged," Manager Singh tells INDIA TODAY. The next burst of activity—Ajanta's full efflorescence—came after a pregnant pause of seven centuries. This time, they improvised on the plaster, creating a complex base out of clay from the Waghora, mixed with ferruginous earth, silicate-rich sand and vegetal matter like rice husk. Then a layer of lime wash. On top of that, blending in animal fat binders, they poured out their inner worlds in resplendent colours—like language bursting forth from silence. The core palette, says Manager Singh, had stayed the same all the way down Palaeolithic Bhimbetka—red ochre, yellow ochre, terraverte for green—now with lampblack, three whites in the shape of ordinary lime, shell lime and kaolin clay, and the conspicuous addition of lapis lazuli from Afghanistan ("there's no blue at all in the earlier paintings"). In terms of creating a canvas that could host eternal beauty, the composite organic plaster was a technological leap. "The hues are much richer," says Manager Singh. But in the pursuit of aesthetics, the fifth century murals had unwittingly sacrificed on longevity. Organic means decay.

Post the sudden and mysterious abandonment of



THE ASI HAS ITS FLAWS, BE IT INSULARITY OR ITS SHAMBOLIC BABU AIR. THE LACK OF A COHESIVE AND COMPREHENSIVE PLAN TO SAVE AJANTA HAS ONLY COMPOUNDED THE PROBLEM